
7-Day Wilderness Threshold Fast Field Manual (v14)

Granite Mountain & Mono Basin, California — Master Ceremonial, Council & Field Operations Guide

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Volume 1: Spiritual Elder Ceremonial & Council Guide

1. Ethos of the Elder & Container Design

As a spiritual elder holding space for a wilderness rite of passage, your role is not that of a guru, master, or dogmatic instructor. The elder acts as a **"lay midwife"** and a **cultivator of an unshakeable, safe container**. In wild nature, the land itself is the primary teacher, mirror, and healer; the elder simply holds the perimeter with radical humility, deep listening, and clean presence.

Key Principles of Elderhood:

- **Radical Humility & Decentering the Ego:** Step back so seekers can encounter the wilderness directly. Avoid interpreting, diagnosing, or analyzing a seeker's experience.
- **Avoiding Cultural Theft ("Plastic Shamanism"):** Honor Native traditions by practicing radical transparency, acknowledging ancestral stewards, avoiding the commercialization or appropriation of sacred rites, and encouraging seekers to connect with their own lineages and authentic presence.
- **Clean, Non-Diagnostic Mirroring:** When seekers return from the mountain and share their stories in council, mirror their courage, emotions, and underlying human themes cleanly without imposing psychological labels or spiritual predictions.
- **Cultivating a Safe, Universal Sanctuary:** Our circle brings together individuals walking paths of recovery, deep grief, clinical depression, aging, and terminal illness, alongside diverse spiritual traditions (Theravada Buddhism, Catholic/Christian devotion, and reverence for the Great Spirit). The elder bridges these paths by anchoring the circle in universal realities: the Land as common ground, Presence as the universal language, and Compassion as the shared heart.

2. Pre-Council Land Permission & Opening Prayer (Day 1)

[LAND PERMISSION PRAYER — GRANITE MOUNTAIN & MONO BASIN]

"Great Mystery, Creator, and Grandfather/Grandmother Earth,
We gather at the foot of Granite Mountain in the Mono Basin.
We humbly acknowledge that we stand upon the ancestral, unceded lands of the
Kootzaduka'a (Mono Lake Northern Paiute), Nüümü, and Newe peoples,
who have loved, prayed upon, and stewarded these granite ridges, alkali waters,
and pinyon groves since time immemorial.

We honor the language of this land and the Kootzaduka'a people, whose very name
carries their sacred relationship to kootzabe—the alkali fly pupae of Mono Lake.
We commit to pronouncing their name with care and reverence, setting aside
English defaults and recognizing that this land spoke Kootzaduka'a thousands
of years before English ever touched this basin.

To the spirits of Granite Mountain, the ancient pinyons, the sagebrush,
and the waters of Mono Lake—we ask for your permission to walk gently.
We ask that you hold these seekers in their solitude and fasting.
We promise to leave no trace, honor your balance, and carry the medicine
of our renewal back to a world in need.

Aho / Amen / Mitákuye Oyás'iy."

Language Sovereignty & The Kootzaduka'a Name:

The elder shares the etymology of **Kootzaduka'a** with the circle as a practical lesson in land ecology and cultural respect:

- **Kootzabe:** The alkali fly pupae native to Mono Lake—an ancestral food source.
- **Duka:** The verb "to eat."
- **A'a:** The suffix indicating "one who does the action," acting as an intensifier that turns an action into an enduring title and identity.
- **The Glottal Stop ('):** The apostrophe before the final a represents a distinct pause in speech, an intentional breath that gives the word its true cadence. Pronouncing the name correctly preserves language sovereignty against English erasure.

3. Spoken Opening Script for Council 1 (Granite Mountain)

(The Elder pauses, strikes a chime or drum gently to settle the air, and invites everyone to take a slow, deep breath together.)

"Welcome back, relatives, to Granite Mountain.

For over twenty-five years, our evolving tribe has returned to these pinyon groves and granite ridges, bringing our quiet presence, our prayers, and our lives back to this soil.

Before we pass the talking piece, we begin by formally acknowledging the ancestral stewards of this watershed—the **Kootzaduka’a** (Mono Lake Northern Paiute), Nüümü, and Newe peoples, who have loved and prayed on this land since time immemorial. We speak the name Kootzaduka’a with intentional care today, honoring their language and their deep identity with kootzabe—the alkali fly pupae of Mono Lake. We recognize that their language echoed off these canyon walls thousands of years before English ever touched this basin, and we ask permission of this mountain, these ancient rocks, and the spirits of this place to walk gently as guests.

Today, we enter the stage of **Severance**—the sacred process of stepping away from daily routines, modern speed, and the busy roles we carry back in the valley.

Our council today rests on four universal intentions: to **speak from the heart**, to **listen from the heart** without judgment, to be **lean in our expression**, and to allow our words to arise **spontaneously** without rehearsing.

This circle is an absolute sanctuary.

For each of us walking a path of recovery, well-being, or deep inner cultivation, know that this mountain is a space of pure rest and dignity. You do not need to fix, fight, or analyze anything here. Allow yourself to drop gently into your body—feeling the solid, unshakeable granite beneath you, the warmth of the high-desert sun on your skin, and the wind moving through the pines.

For those of us sitting with deep grief—holding the memory and love of a partner or dear one who has passed—the mountain is vast enough to hold the full depth of your love and sorrow without judgment or haste. On this land, you can create a quiet space or Death Lodge to speak the words of completion: 'I forgive you,' 'Please forgive me,' 'Thank you,' 'I love you,' and 'Goodbye'.

And as we sit here in circle, we hold court for those we know and love who are experiencing aging, frailty, or ill-health. We hold their well-being, comfort, and peace at the center of our thoughts as we do our work on the land. As we sit in silence, we dedicate our practice and send unconditional loving-kindness and compassion to those in need.

Whether you pray to God, honor Wakǫ́ng Tǫ́ngka—the Great Spirit—or rest in the quiet, unconditioned awareness of mindfulness and Theravada practice, know that we are all drinking from the exact same waterhole. The land does not demand a single doctrine; it only asks for our presence.

Let us take one more collective breath.

As we sit here in circle, we might consider what brings us to this mountain today, and what intent we wish to hold in our hearts as we step toward the threshold."

4. Complete 7-Day Ceremonial Arc & Council Guide

Day & Phase	Geographical & Ceremonial Focus	Elder Guidance & Council Theme	Focus / Inquiry
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Day 1: Arrival & Severance	Basecamp set at base of Granite Mountain. Land permission prayer offered.	1st Council (Severance): Acknowledging Kootzaduka'a land; stepping out of modern speed; establishing the circle as a sanctuary for recovery, grief, and presence.	"As we sit here in circle, we might consider what brings us to this mountain today, and what intent we wish to hold in our hearts as we step toward the threshold."
Day 2: Scouting, Vetting & Vow	Scouting solo spots among pinyon/granite ridges (200–400 yd buffers).	2nd Council (Declaring Intent): Teaching the Sacred Hoop of the Four Directions; solidifying personal vows; reviewing safety/stone check protocols before crossing threshold.	"Having found your spot on this mountain, what is the core vow or prayer you carry into the quiet of the fast?"
Days 3-5: 72-Hour Solo Fast	Solitary vigil on Granite Mountain slopes. Fasting, silence, non-contact stone checks.	Threshold Vigil: Basecamp maintains quiet prayer/safety container. Seekers engage somatic grounding, the Death Lodge, the Land as Mirror, and crying for a vision (Hanblecheya).	Solitude & Silence. Land acts as the primary teacher. Basecamp holds quiet Metta & safety vigil.
Day 6: Threshold Return & Mirroring	Re-crossing threshold at dawn; gathering at basecamp for break-fast broth & fruit.	Council of the Mirror: First story circle. Elder practices clean, non-diagnostic mirroring—reflecting the quester's courage, emotion, and human myth without psychological labeling.	"Listen to your story as a gift brought back from the mountain for the whole tribe."
Day 7: Re-incorporation & Strike	Morning circle, 90-day integration vows, ash scattering, camp strike.	Final Council (Re-incorporation): Translating vision into service, love, and everyday life. Closing thanks to land, ancestors, and Kootzaduka'a elders.	"As you return home tonight, what single practical act of presence or care will embody the medicine you gathered on the mountain?"

5. The Sacred Hoop of the Four Directions

(from Doug Good Feather, Think Indigenous)

- **East (Wiyóhpiyata) — Fire & New Beginnings:** The morning light, awakening vision, gratitude, and generosity.
- **South (Itókagata) — Air & The Breath of Life:** Summer vitality, innocence, mental clarity, and walking with honest integrity.
- **West (Wiyóhpeyata) — Water & Healing Powers:** Sunset, the emotional depths, humility, surrender, and the courage to release old grief.
- **North (Wazíyata) — Earth Medicine & Fortitude:** Winter stillness, the deep roots of the ancestors, compassion, endurance, and physical grounding.
- **Above (Waŋkátab) & Below (Khúta):** The Great Mystery above and Mother Earth below, uniting within the Center of Life (Čhaŋté / Heart).

6. Stories, Poems, & Meditations for Silence and Solitude

Stillness and the Cosmos (Ancient & Contemplative Maxims)

"To the mind that is still, the whole universe surrenders." — **Lao Tzu**

"Of what avail is it if we can travel to the moon, if we cannot cross the abyss that separates us from ourselves?" — **Thomas Merton**

"We should live our lives in a sacred manner, and always be mindful of the Great Spirit. We should be kind to one another and to all living things. We should live in harmony with the Earth, and always remember that we are all connected." — **Black Elk**

"Mindfulness is the key to balance. When you are mindful, you are aware in the present moment without judgment. You are not dwelling on the past or worrying about the future. You are simply being." — **Thomas Yellowtail**

Letting Go into Deep Mind

(by Keith Kristich, from Poems & prayers for silence & meditation)

In letting go of thoughts and thinking, we sink into Deep Mind.

In letting go of emotion and feeling, we sink into Deep Heart.

In letting go of action and doing, we sink into Deep Being.

In letting go of self and other, we sink into Deep One.

In letting go of letting go, we recognize that we were never holding on.

We have always and only ever rested in the Beloved.

The Fullness of Silence

(by Carla A. Grosch-Miller, from Poems & prayers for silence & meditation)

O Lord, my heart is open

and my mind is freed
from the struggle to make sense
even of who, of how, You are.
(I breathe.)

I come to the broad plain,
the fullness of silence.
Peace envelops me.
I sink into You.
I want for nothing.
(This is the still point of the turning world.)
I rest in You.

The Tigers and the Wild Strawberry

(Zen Parable)

A seeker was walking alone through the wild forest when he heard the low, earth-shaking growl of a tiger behind him. He ran harder than he had ever run in his life until the ground abruptly ended at the lip of a precipitous cliff.

With no choice, he caught hold of a wild vine swinging over the abyss and lowered himself over the precipice. Dangling in midair, he looked down. Waiting at the bottom of the canyon rocks was a second hungry tiger, gazing upward in patient certainty. Above him, the first tiger paced the cliff edge.

Suspended between two deaths, the man looked closely at the vine that held him. From a cleft in the rock emerged two mice—one white, one black. Little by little, in steady alternation—day and night—they began to gnaw at the fibrous stem. He heard the fibers snapping one by one.

In that moment of absolute stillness, where there was nowhere left to run, no future to plan, and no past to regret, he noticed something growing from a crevice within arm's reach: a single wild strawberry, crimson, glistening in the sunlight, completely alive.

Reaching out with one free hand, he plucked the berry and placed it on his tongue.

It was the sweetest thing he had ever tasted in his entire life.

Not because the berry possessed magical power, but because for the first time in his life, he was unreservedly, completely present. The tigers of mortality are always there—yesterday, today, and tomorrow. The only question the quest asks is: **Are you present enough to taste the strawberry?**

The Muddy Road: Leaving the Burden Behind

(Zen Story of Tanzan & Ekido)

Two monks, Tanzan and Ekido, were walking along a rain-drenched country road. The mud was deep and thick. At an impassable crossroads stood a young woman in an exquisite silk kimono, unable to cross without ruining her clothes.

Without a word or hesitation, Tanzan scooped the woman up into his arms, carried her across the deep mud, set her down gently on dry ground, and walked on.

Ekido said nothing, but inwardly he seethed. Hours passed in stony silence. Night fell, and when they finally arrived at the temple lodging, Ekido could bear it no longer:

"We monks are forbidden to touch women, let alone pick them up and hold them! Why did you do that? It is against our sacred vows!"

Tanzan looked at his companion with calm compassion and smiled:

"I left the girl on the other side of the road hours ago. Why are you still carrying her?"

Quest Medicine: On the mountain, we discover how much baggage—resentments, identities, rules, grievances—we have carried up the hill. The wilderness invites us to set down what ended long ago.

Each Life, Its Own Mountain and River

Every life is its own vast mountain and sea. We are born into different fires, raised under different skies. The storms we've witnessed vary, and the warmth and cold we carry in our hearts are never the same.

Some are surrounded by flowers from birth — gentle and open, never knowing the bite of frost. Others grow up dancing with the wind and rain — learning to hold their own umbrella, quietly hiding their scars.

Between travelers lie gaps of circumstance, trial, and perspective. Blooming has its brilliance; wilderness has its own quiet peace. Passion is one way to live — stillness is another worthy path.

You have your flower-strewn path. I have my thorny trail.

We need not look up to each other, nor look down.

We simply walk our own journeys and allow the other to do the same.

With kindness in our words, clarity in our sight, acceptance of differences, and compassion for every circumstance — this is the finest practice for the rest of our lives.

7. Translations for the Return & Re-incorporation

A vision quest is never completed for the quester alone. Indigenous wisdom reminds us that we fast and pray on the mountain so that our people, our families, and the Earth may live with greater wisdom. When the solo ends, the vision must be translated into service, love, and courageous living.

Reincorporation & Council

(from Tony Manyhorses, What is a Vision Quest)

"The return from the quest can be a time of great energy and joy. Life is new; one has been reborn. But the **reincorporation** phase is a challenge. How does one bring Vision back into the world of work, relationship, and everyday life?

We meet in council, in which the sharing of our experience deepens the understanding of our lessons, and their integration into our lives.

The energy of the Vision Quest flows into us as a healing, and from us, enters the world."

When Death Comes

(by Mary Oliver)

When death comes
like the hungry bear in autumn;
when death comes and takes all the bright coins from his purse
to buy me, and snaps the purse shut;
when death comes
like the measles-pox;
when death comes
like an iceberg between the shoulder blades,

I want to step through the door full of curiosity, wondering:
what is it going to be like, that cottage of darkness?

And therefore I look upon everything
as a brotherhood and a sisterhood,
and I look upon time as no more than an idea,
and I consider eternity as another possibility,

and I think of each life as a flower, as common
as a field daisy, and as singular,

and each name a comfortable music in the mouth,
tending, as all music does, toward silence,

and each body a lion of courage, and something
precious to the earth.

When it's over, I want to say all my life
I was a bride married to amazement.
I was the bridegroom, taking the world into my arms.

When it's over, I don't want to wonder
if I have made of my life something particular, and real.

I don't want to find myself sighing and frightened,
or full of argument.

I don't want to end up simply having visited this world.

Our Deepest Light

(by Marianne Williamson, from A Return To Love)

"Our deepest fear is not that we are inadequate.

Our deepest fear is that we are powerful beyond measure.

It is our light, not our darkness, that most frightens us.

We ask ourselves, who am I to be brilliant, gorgeous, talented, fabulous?

Actually, who are you not to be?

You are a child of God. Your playing small does not serve the world.

There is nothing enlightened about shrinking so that other people won't feel insecure around you.

We were born to make manifest the glory of God that is within us.

It is not just in some of us; it is in everyone.

And as we let our own light shine,

we unconsciously give other people permission to do the same.

As we are liberated from our own fear,

our presence automatically liberates others."

The Quester's Daily Benediction

"Ask yourself what makes you come alive, and go do that, because what the world needs is people who have come alive."

— **Howard Thurman**

"Enjoy life's journey, but leave no tracks."

— **Traditional Precept**

8. Daily Ending Quotes for Council (Days 1-7)

• Day 1 (Severance & Boundary):

> "Stand still. The trees ahead and bushes beside you / Are not lost. Wherever you are is called Here, / And you must treat it as a powerful stranger, / Must ask permission to know it and be known." — **David Wagoner**

• Day 2 (Intent & Vow):

> "Have patience with everything unresolved in your heart and try to love the questions themselves as if they were locked rooms... Live the questions now." — **Rainer Maria Rilke**

• Day 3 (Solo Fast — Entering Solitude):

> "The only true wisdom lives far from people, out in the great solitude..." — **Najagneq** (Inuit Elder)

• Day 4 (Solo Fast — Deep Silence & Mirror of Nature):

> "You do not have to be good... You only have to let the soft animal of your body love what it loves."
— **Mary Oliver**

- **Day 5 (Solo Fast — Crying for a Vision):**

> "We go on the hill because we realize our nothingness before the Great Mystery. We cry from our hearts: 'Pity me, that my people may live.'" — **Lakota Teaching**

- **Day 6 (Dawn Re-Crossing & Council of the Mirror):**

> "The ultimate aim of the quest... must be neither release nor ecstasy for oneself, but the wisdom and the power to serve others." — **Joseph Campbell**

- **Day 7 (Morning Re-incorporation & Gratitude):**

> "Vision without execution is a hallucination." — **Thomas Edison** (Elder's addition: "Now, sweep the floor.")

9. Day 7 Morning Circle & Camp Strike

1. **Circle Opening:** Gather at 07:00 AM.

2. **Inquiry:** "As you return home tonight, what single practical act of presence or care will embody the medicine you gathered on the mountain?"

3. **Gratitude Ritual:** Thank basecamp guides, ancestors, and the Kootzaduka'a elders. Walk to the fire pit, take a handful of cold ash, and give it back to the soil as an offering of peace and thanksgiving.

4. **Camp Strike:** Naturalize all solo spots, deconstruct stone circles, and ensure the site is left immaculate.

10. Ethical Reading List for Non-Native Spiritual Advisors

- **Wanting To Be Indian: When Spiritual Searching Turns Into Cultural Theft** (Rev. Myke Johnson)

- **Braiding Sweetgrass: Indigenous Wisdom, Scientific Knowledge, and Plant Teachings** (Robin Wall Kimmerer)

- **Think Indigenous: Native American Spirituality for a Modern World** (Doug Good Feather)

- **Blackfoot Physics: A Dialogue Between Worlds** (F. David Peat)

- **God Is Red: A Native View of Religion** (Vine Deloria Jr.)

- **The Ohlone Way** (Malcolm Margolin)

- **The Book of the Vision Quest & The Way of Council** (Steven Foster, Meredith Little, Jack Zimmerman, Gigi Coyle)

Volume 2: Quest Leader Field Operations & Safety Manual

1. Topographic Vetting & Site Scouting (Granite Mountain)

- **Buffer Zone:** Maintain 200–400 yard buffers between solo sites and 0.5 miles from basecamp.

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- **Flash Flood Mitigation:** Avoid dry arroyo beds and wash bottoms; select elevated granite benches.
 - **Widowmaker Audit:** Inspect pinyon pine canopy for dead limbs or unstable snags.
 - **GPS Waypoints:** Log all site locations into master GPS unit and physical topo maps.

2. Twice-Daily Silent Stone-Pile Safety Checks

- **Morning Window:** 07:00 – 08:30 AM | **Evening Window:** 17:00 – 18:30 PM.
- **Binary Rock Switch:** Seeker flips designated top rock from horizontal to vertical position.
- **Message Tin:** Sealed waterproof tin at safety pile for written notes or non-verbal communication.
- **No-Contact Protocol:** Safety patrols observe stone piles silently without entering solo territory unless switch is un-flipped.

3. Emergency Distress & Escalation Protocol

- **Distress Signal:** 3 sharp whistle blasts or high-tied orange flag = immediate rescue response.
- **Missed Check Escalation:**

Stage 1 (T+15 min):* Visual verification of stone pile from buffer edge.

Stage 2 (T+45 min):* Voice call from perimeter.

Stage 3 (T+60 min):* Two-person team enters solo site with medical kit.

- **Compassion Check-In Jar:** Waterproof jar at safety pile containing non-verbal check-in slips for participants needing quiet support.

4. High-Desert Medical & Fasting Hydration

- **Hydration Rule:** Minimum 4–6 Liters of clean water per day in high-desert environment.
- **Monitoring:** Watch for signs of heat exhaustion, altitude headaches, and severe electrolyte drops.
- **Phased Re-feeding Schedule:**

Phase 1 (Break-Fast):* Warm vegetable broth, watermelon/cucumber slices.

Phase 2 (Evening Day 6):* Miso soup, plain congee/rice porridge. Avoid dairy, heavy oils, and meat.